



GARGOYLE GECKO · RHACODACTYLUS
AURICULATUS

The horned climber with a low ceiling.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: the tall, cluttered enclosure, a gentle gradient under an 86°F (30°C) limit, a humidity cycle that dries out every day, the powder-plus-insects diet this gecko needs, and the health pages that start with the two husbandry mistakes behind most of its problems.

INSIDE

- ✓ The vertical setup, the gradient, and a chart of the daily wet-dry cycle
- ✓ Six health pages, from bone disease to floppy tail and stuck shed
- ✓ Powder and insects by age, and a weight table to track growth
- ✓ Fillable owner, vet and sitter sheets, and a heat-wave plan

42 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't bought a gecko yet

Read pages 4 through 10 in order before buying anything, then the feeding section. Two decisions are the expensive ones to get wrong. The first is the enclosure on page 5: it has to be tall, and it has to be packed with branches, because this gecko grips branches better than glass and sleeping on bare glass is what bends its tail. The second is the heat on page 6: a gentle warm spot, and a room that never pushes the air past 86°F (30°C). Settle both, then use the Budget and Shopping List on page 30 to buy once instead of twice.

If your gecko is already home

Start with the Setup Checklist on page 28 to audit what you have. Then read the humidity cycle on page 7: an enclosure that never dries out causes respiratory infection, and one that stays too dry causes the stuck shed that costs this species its toes. Then weigh the gecko and start the log on page 37, because a falling weight is usually the first sign of trouble. If anything already looks wrong, go straight to Health Red Flags on page 22.

Print these first

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|--|---|
| ☐ Page 28: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 36: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 29: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 37: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 33: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 38: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 34: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 15: Weight, Growth & Body Condition |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

The gargoyle gecko is usually sold as "a crested gecko with horns", and the two do share an island, a powdered diet and a tall enclosure. The differences are what catch new keepers out. This gecko needs live insects as a real part of its diet, not a treat. It grips branches better than glass. Its tail grows back, and its bite can break skin. And the most repeated advice about it, that it needs no heat at all, is wrong: it needs a gentle warm spot, with a ceiling it must never pass. Every figure here is cross-checked against the veterinary and species sources listed on page 41, and every temperature and dimension is given in both imperial and metric.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) with centimeters (cm) beside them. Weights are in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows, with ounces (oz) for the powder bag. Humidity is a percentage (%) of the moisture the air could hold. Prices are in United States dollars.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A veterinarian who treats reptiles. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care, and anything urgent is a professional call, not a page in this book. Not every practice sees reptiles, so find one before you need one, and write the number on page 29.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Rhacodactylus auriculatus</i> , described in 1869. Named for the bony, horn-like bumps on its head, which resemble a stone gargoyle's
Native range	Southern New Caledonia, a group of islands between Australia and Fiji, the same islands as the crested gecko. Humid forest and scrub, on shrubs and saplings, mostly within a few meters of the ground
Adult size	7 to 9 in (18 to 23 cm) including the tail. About 45 to 65 g as an adult, depending on sex and genetics
Captive lifespan	15 to 20 years typical, with some keepers reporting animals still breeding past 20. Wild lifespan has not been studied
Activity	Arboreal, meaning it lives off the ground, climbing. Sleepier by day and active after dark
Diet	Omnivore. A complete powdered diet as the base, plus live insects, which this species needs. Page 11
Enclosure, one adult	18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) minimum, the 24 in being height; 24×24×24 in (61×61×61 cm) ideal. One gecko per enclosure
Temperature	Cool end 70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C), basking spot 82 to 85°F (28 to 29°C). Air never above 86°F (30°C), never below 65°F (18°C)
Humidity	50 to 70%: a heavy evening mist, then a dry-back toward 50% before the next one. Page 7
UVB	UVB (ultraviolet B) is the band of ultraviolet light that lets a gecko make its own vitamin D3, the vitamin it needs to use calcium. Optional for this species and worth having: a low-output tube, 12 hours a day. Page 8
Handling	Adults calm and slow; juveniles jumpy. The tail drops if grabbed and grows back. A bite is rare and can break skin
Conservation status	Least Concern on the IUCN Red List, the global list of species at risk kept by the International Union for Conservation of Nature. New Caledonia stopped issuing export permits, so pet geckos descend from founders exported decades ago. Every one for sale should be captive-bred

Cost overview

Initial setup

The gecko is \$50 to \$300 for a common reticulated (net-patterned) or striped animal, \$500 to \$1,000 or more for a premium color line. Itemized with the heat lamp, thermostat, first food and supplements, the setup comes to **\$350 to \$660**. With a first vet exam and a common gecko, plan on **\$450 to \$1,110**. Page 30 has every line.

Ongoing

Diet, insects, supplements, two UVB tubes, electricity and a yearly checkup run **\$320 to \$565 a year**. Food and supplements run about \$15 to \$30 a month. An illness visit with tests runs \$150 to \$600.

THE NUMBER THAT SHOULD DRIVE THE DECISION

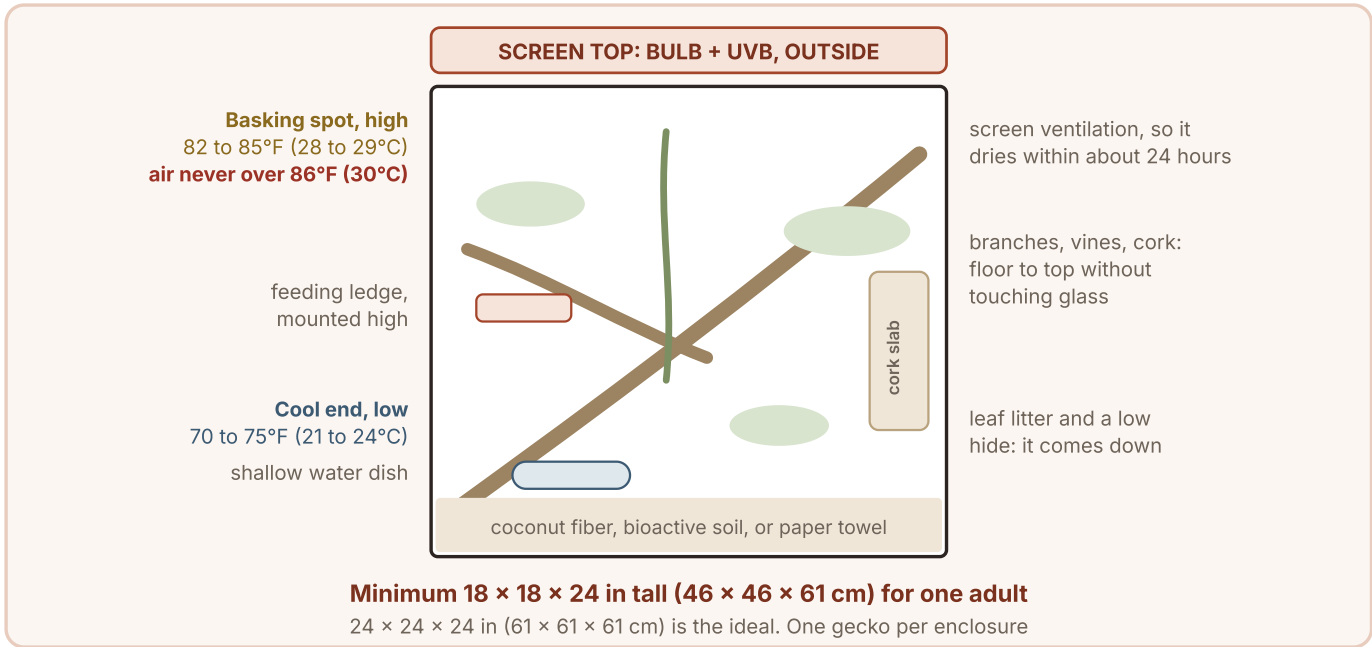
Not the price. The lifespan. A gecko bought for a ten-year-old is very likely still alive when that child is in their late twenties. At \$320 to \$565 a year for 15 to 20 years, the routine care alone comes to roughly \$4,800 to \$11,300, before a single emergency.

The vertical enclosure & where it goes

A climbing gecko measures its home in height, and the height only counts once it is filled.

18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) is the minimum for one adult, with the 24 in as height, and **24×24×24 in (61×61×61 cm) is the ideal**. Vertical space matters more than floor space for an arboreal species. Hatchlings and juveniles under about 12 g do better in a smaller grow-out enclosure for a while, where they find food easily and you can find them. A screen top and real airflow matter as much as the size: the enclosure should dry out within about 24 hours after misting.

One gecko per enclosure. Gargoyle geckos are territorial, they can eat hatchlings, and they are known for nipping each other's tails. Page 20 covers why pairs are a breeding decision, not company.



Where the enclosure goes

PLACE	WHY
Away from sunny windows	Room heat is what most often pushes this gecko past its 86°F (30°C) ceiling, and a glass box in sun traps it. A summer heat wave is a bigger risk than a cold snap.
Off radiators, heat vents and drafts	Each one swings the temperature and dries the air, which fights the humidity cycle on page 7
Not in the kitchen	Reptiles carry <i>Salmonella</i> , a germ that gives people food-poisoning-type illness, without looking sick, and the hygiene rules on page 10 start with keeping them away from food

The gradient @ the 86°F ceiling

Not "no heat needed". A gentle warm spot, and very little headroom above it.

ZONE	°F	°C
Cool end, low in the enclosure	70 to 75	21 to 24
Basking spot, high on one side	82 to 85	28 to 29
General air temperature, daytime	at or below about 82	about 28
Night	low 70s, or down to the mid-60s	about 18 to 23
Never let the air pass	86	30
Never let it fall below	65	18

The two bold lines are limits, not targets. Air above 86°F (30°C) is dangerous for this species, a lower ceiling than almost any other lizard in the hobby.

Why it still needs heat

"Gargoyle geckos need no heat" is the most repeated mistake about this species, and it is wrong. A gecko is ectothermic: its body runs at the temperature of its surroundings, and it warms or cools itself by moving between warmer and cooler spots. A room that suits people gives it no gradient to choose from. A gecko kept too cool also digests poorly, and a warm side that runs cold is a common, fixable reason it stops eating. What is different about this species is not the need for heat but how little room there is above the basking spot.

The heat source

PART	HOW IT IS USED
Low-wattage bulb	A low-wattage basking bulb or a ceramic heat emitter (a bulb-shaped heater that gives heat and no light), in a dome over one side of the screen top, outside the enclosure, so the top branches reach the basking range
Thermostat	The bulb runs through one, so a hot day or a bulb that is too strong cannot push the enclosure past the ceiling. Its probe goes at gecko level, on or beside the top basking branch
Two readings	Digital, one high at the basking spot and one low at the cool end. Check both against each other daily: a thermostat stuck on, or a probe that slipped and reads room air, is the failure that matters

WATCH THE ROOM, NOT JUST THE BULB

In summer the room itself can do the heating. If the enclosure reads above 82°F (28°C) with the bulb off, the bulb stays off, and page 35 has the heat-wave plan. Never leave a dome lamp running on a timer alone with no thermostat behind it.

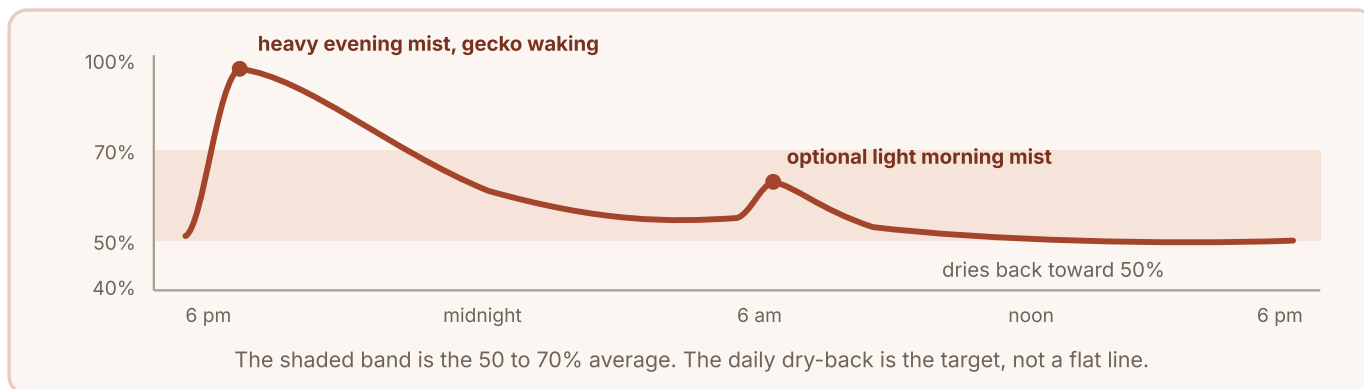
Signs the gradient is wrong

YOU NOTICE	CHECK
Any reading over 86°F (30°C)	Turn the heat off now, then find out whether the bulb, the thermostat or the room did it. Page 26
Eating less, slow to digest, for days	A warm side that runs too cool. Check the basking spot against 82 to 85°F (28 to 29°C)
Night reading under 65°F (18°C)	A cold room. Heat the room or run the bulb on its thermostat into the evening
Both thermometers, set side by side on the same spot for ten minutes, differ by more than a degree or two	One has drifted. Replace it rather than averaging them

The humidity cycle, misting & airflow

Most of this gecko's health problems come from getting this page wrong in one direction or the other.

Aim for **50 to 70% on average**. Mist heavily in the evening, as the gecko wakes, and then let the enclosure **dry back toward 50% before misting again**. A heavy evening mist can briefly push humidity to 80 to 100%, and a light mist in the morning is optional. The swing matters more than hitting an exact number. An enclosure that never dries causes **respiratory infection**; one that stays too dry causes **stuck shed**, which can strangle a toe.



Water: droplets first, a dish as well

Gargoyle geckos mostly drink droplets off leaves and walls rather than from a dish, so the evening mist is the main drink of the day. A shallow dish of fresh, dechlorinated water (tap water treated to remove its chlorine) still goes in, emptied and refilled daily. Water runs on a short clock: **no gecko should go more than 2 to 3 days without water**, whatever its appetite.

Holding the cycle in practice

- **Read it twice.** A digital hygrometer (humidity meter) mid-height, away from where you spray: once an hour after the evening mist, and again the next afternoon. Those two numbers are the cycle.
- **Mist the surfaces, not the gecko.** Leaves, cork and glass, until they bead.
- **Never dries back?** More airflow, less misting, and look for soggy substrate. Condensation all day, a musty smell or mold are the signs.
- **Too dry by afternoon?** More live plants, or cover a small part of the screen. Change one thing, then wait two days to judge it.

VENTILATION IS HALF OF HUMIDITY

Cutting ventilation to hold in humidity or heat frequently causes skin and respiratory disease. A screen top is not a flaw to be covered up; it is how the enclosure dries out within about 24 hours after misting.

UVB light & the day length

Survivable without, because the diet carries vitamin D3. Better with, at a low level.

A gargoyle gecko can survive without UVB, because a complete powdered diet supplies vitamin D3, the vitamin a gecko needs to absorb and use calcium. Low-level UVB still brings real digestive and immune benefits, and lack of UVB is one of the listed causes of metabolic bone disease. This is a gecko that spends its days in leaf shade, so the right tube is a weak one.

SETTING	NUMBER
Tube	A 12 in (30 cm) low-output T5 HO tube , sold as a 5.0, which means about 5% UVB. T5 is the slim fluorescent tube size, 5/8 inch across, and HO means high output, the tube format; the low 5% is what keeps it gentle. In a reflector fixture across the top
Strength at the gecko	A UV index (UVI), the standard scale for UVB strength, of roughly 1.0 to 2.0 at the basking area, if you own a UV meter. Fluorescent UVB has to sit fairly close to work: the basking spot 6 to 12 in (15 to 30 cm) below the tube, never closer than 6 in
Day length	12 hours on, 12 hours off , on a timer. No light overnight, colored night bulbs included
Replace the tube	Every 6 to 12 months , on the maker's schedule, whether or not it still lights. The budget on page 30 assumes the 6-month change, two a year

GLASS AND PLASTIC BLOCK IT

Most glass and clear plastic filter out UVB, so a tube sitting on a glass lid, or an enclosure near a sunny window, delivers far less than it seems to. Mount the fixture directly over open mesh. A window is never the UVB source: through glass it is only a heat trap, and heat is this gecko's real risk.

The tube that still glows

A UVB tube keeps producing visible light long after its UVB output has dropped. That is why it is replaced on a date rather than when it looks tired, and why the date it went in belongs on the equipment log on page 38. A UV index meter is the only way to know the tube is at the right height and when to replace it; UV cards show total UV, not the UVB that makes vitamin D3.

UVB and the supplement jar are one decision

The complete diet powder already carries calcium and vitamin D3, and a gecko under a working tube also makes its own D3. So the calcium dusted onto insects is mostly plain calcium without D3, with a D3 product only periodically. Vitamin D3 builds up in the body rather than washing out, so more is not safer. The schedule is on page 13.

LIGHT NEEDS SHADE BESIDE IT

A gecko that sleeps by day needs somewhere to get out of the light. Broad leaves and cork are what make a lit enclosure livable, and a gecko that is always fully exposed under the tube needs more cover, not less light.

Substrate, clutter & furnishings

Sparse decor is the wrong instinct for this species. Clutter is health care.

Substrate

CHOICE	VERDICT	NOTES
Coconut fiber	GOOD	Holds humidity well. Loose substrate with no cleanup crew is spot cleaned daily and replaced monthly
Bioactive soil mix	GOOD	A living, planted floor over a drainage layer, with a cleanup crew of springtails and isopods (tiny soil animals and woodlice) that break down waste. The substrate stays in place
Paper towel	SIMPLE	Best for hatchlings, a sick gecko and quarantine: easy to clean and to check droppings on
Sand, wood chips, gravel	NEVER	The substrates that carry a real risk of impaction, a gut blockage from swallowed particles. Page 27

Soil and coconut fiber are a different case from sand and chips: this is a climbing species that spends most of its time off the floor, and soil-based and bioactive substrates are the standard recommendation for it.

Why clutter is not optional

Gargoyle geckos climb smooth glass noticeably worse than crested geckos do, so grippable branches matter more here. And a gecko with nowhere better to rest ends up sleeping hanging upside down on bare glass, which is linked to **floppy tail syndrome**, a tail that bends over the back and can deform the hips. Branches, vines and cork give it somewhere else to sleep. **The test: can the gecko get from the floor to the top without touching glass?**

Furnishings

- **Branches at every angle.** Horizontal, diagonal and vertical, so it can climb, jump and rest at different heights. Anchor every one: a perch that shifts mid-jump is a fall.
- **Cork slabs and tubes.** Vertical slabs, and tubes mounted high as well as low, so it can hide wherever it happens to be. A background with ledges turns dead wall into climbing surface.
- **Dense planting**, live or artificial, at every level. Broad leaves and moss also hold droplets after misting.
- **The bottom third.** Wild gargoyles spend time near and on the ground, so leaf litter, a low cork hollow and ground-level plants give it a reason to come down.
- **A feeding ledge mounted high** and a **shallow water dish** low.

EVERY PIECE EARNS ITS PLACE

Each item should do at least one of three jobs: a place to hide, a place to climb or jump, or a surface that holds water droplets after misting. If the gecko is always in plain view, there is not enough in there.

Cleaning & hygiene

Three cleaning clocks for the enclosure, and the hand-washing habits that protect the people in the house.

The cleaning routine

WHEN	WHAT
Daily	Remove droppings, urates (the white, chalky part of a reptile's droppings), uneaten food and shed skin as soon as you see them. Empty, wash and refill the water dish with fresh dechlorinated water
Weekly	Replace soiled loose substrate in sections, and wipe down glass, walls and decor with a reptile-safe cleaner
Monthly	Move the gecko to a secure temporary tub. Take everything out, scrub it with detergent and hot water, disinfect the enclosure, decor and dishes, rinse, dry, and refill with new substrate

A bioactive enclosure is the exception: it skips the monthly strip-down, because the living substrate is the point. Pick up the droppings and food you can see, and let the cleanup crew handle the rest.

Disinfecting, properly

Cleaning removes the dirt; disinfecting kills what is left, and it only works on a surface that has already been scrubbed. Household bleach at a **1:32 dilution**, half a cup of bleach per gallon of water, is cheap and effective. It needs **10 minutes of wet contact**, so keep the surface wet for the full time rather than wiping it straight off. Then rinse with plenty of clean water until no bleach smell remains, and let everything dry and air out completely, a full day, before the gecko goes back in.

Salmonella: the germ healthy geckos carry

Salmonella is a bacterium that causes diarrhea, fever and stomach cramps in people. Healthy-looking reptiles carry it in the gut and shed it in their droppings with no sign of illness, on and off, so one negative test clears nothing. It is not only a turtle problem: a United States public health investigation into infections linked to pet geckos, closed in January 2026, counted **113 cases and 31 hospitalizations across 36 states**. It spreads from hands and surfaces to mouth, not by bites.

THE RULE	IN PRACTICE
Wash after every contact	Soap and running water after touching the gecko, its enclosure, its water, or anything that touched either
Keep it out of the kitchen	Never on a counter or anywhere food is made or eaten
Never wash gear in a sink or tub people use	Not the kitchen sink, the bathroom sink or the bathtub. Use a plastic tub kept only for the gecko; if a bathtub has to be used, clean it thoroughly afterward
No kissing	And no holding the gecko close to your face
Children under 5	Should not handle the gecko or touch its enclosure at all. Older children are supervised and wash every time

WHO IS AT HIGHER RISK

Children under 5, adults over 65, pregnant people and anyone with a weakened immune system. If anyone in the house gets diarrhea, fever and cramps, mention the gecko to the doctor, even if nobody remembers touching it.

SECTION 03 · FEEDING

Diet & feeding by age

A powder for the base, and live insects that this gecko actually needs.

Gargoyle geckos look like their crested gecko cousins at the food dish, but they are more carnivorous, and that changes what a complete diet means. The base is a **complete powdered gecko diet**, a commercial powder mixed with water. On top of that, **live insects are a required part of the diet**, not optional enrichment as they are for a crested gecko. Wild gargoyles have been documented eating other lizards, young crested geckos included, alongside insects.

STAGE	COMPLETE DIET POWDER	LIVE INSECTS
Hatchling and juvenile , 0 to 12 months	Fresh, daily	1 to 2 times a week
Adult , from 12 to 18 months, at about 40 g	Fresh, every 2 to 3 days	1 to 2 times a week

Weight on page 15 corrects the schedule either way: a gecko gaining too fast gets insects less often, one losing gets them more.

How a feeding works

- **Evening.** The gecko is awake and moving after dark, around the time of the main misting.
- **High up.** Powder goes in a small cup or on a feeding ledge near the top. This is a climbing species, and many will not come down to a floor dish.
- **Insects released into the planting,** so they have to be hunted. That is enrichment as well as food.
- **Clear up.** Pull uneaten insects a few hours later, and take out made-up powder before it spoils.
- **Gravid females,** carrying eggs, may stop eating for a week or more before laying. Page 21.

Water

Most drinking is droplets licked off leaves after the evening mist, with a shallow dish of fresh dechlorinated water as a backup, refilled daily. Water is the time-critical one: **no more than 2 to 3 days without water access**, whatever the gecko's appetite. Food runs on a much longer clock, page 14.

WEIGH, DON'T GUESS

A gram scale is the most useful feeding tool you can own for this species. Regular weighing is the most objective way to catch a real problem early, and a thinning tail, where this gecko stores fat, is the visible early sign of weight loss. Log the weight on page 37.

Complete diet powder: mixing & rotation

The base of the diet. Get this right and the rest of the food pages are additions.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Complete powdered gecko diet , the crested gecko formulas	STAPLE	A meal replacement mixed with water, carrying protein, fruit, calcium and vitamin D3 in one product
Three or more flavors or brands, rotated	STAPLE	Rotate 3 or more for variety and to head off a picky eater
Fruit puree alongside the powder	OCCASIONAL	Calcium-rich, low-phosphorus fruits only, offered beside the powder, never instead of it.
Processed or sugary human food	NEVER	The wrong nutrient profile for a gecko

Mixing and serving

- **Roughly 2 to 3 parts water to 1 part powder**, stirred to a smooth, ketchup-like consistency.
- Serve in a small cup or on a **feeding ledge mounted high**, where a climbing gecko feeds.
- **Mix fresh for each feeding.** Dry powder keeps; made-up diet does not.
- **Remove uneaten made-up diet within 24 to 48 hours** so it cannot go moldy.
- Nothing gets stirred into the powder. It is already complete, calcium and vitamin D3 included, so supplements go on the insects instead.

How long a bag lasts

One 8 oz (227 g) bag of powdered diet lasts a single adult about two months and runs \$20 to \$30, so plan on six bags a year. With three flavors in rotation, buy smaller amounts of each, keep them sealed and dry, and note the opening date on the bag.

When a gecko leaves its powder

Pickiness is the first thing to rule out: rotate to a different flavor or brand before anything else. Look at the husbandry next, because a warm side that runs too cool slows digestion and drops appetite. Shedding, the breeding season and a recent move all cause normal dips. Only then treat it as a health question, using the thresholds on page 14.

POWDER FIRST, INSECTS SECOND, BOTH ALWAYS

A crested gecko keeper is told insects are an optional extra. For a gargoyle they are not, but they are still the second half of the diet, not the base. A gecko that fills up on insects and leaves its powder is missing the part formulated to be complete. Keep insects to the weekly schedule.

Feeder insects & supplements

Commercially raised, fed well before they are offered, and dusted.

INSECT	TIER	NOTES
Dubia roaches	STAPLE	Gut-loaded and dusted. A little better on calcium than crickets, still far short on their own
Discoïd and red runner roaches	STAPLE	Interchangeable with dubia in the rotation
Crickets	STAPLE	Active prey that brings out hunting. Pull any still loose a few hours later
Black soldier fly larvae	STAPLE	The one common feeder that is not calcium-poor: the exoskeleton, the hard outer shell, carries real calcium
Hornworms, waxworms, butterworms	TREAT	Fattier. Occasional treats, not staples
Pinky mice, newborn mice	RARE	Some keepers use one once or twice a month at most, as enrichment. Overuse causes obesity, and nothing about the diet requires them
Insects caught outdoors	NEVER	Real pesticide and parasite risk, however clean the garden looks

Gut-loading: the insect's last meal

Feeder insects are poor calcium sources, and the problem is the ratio: an unsupplemented cricket carries about 1 part calcium to 9 parts phosphorus, and phosphorus competes with calcium for absorption. **Gut-loading** means feeding the insects a high-calcium diet for **24 to 48 hours** before they go to the gecko, so the calcium in their gut goes along with them. Use a commercial gut-load sold on its calcium content, or calcium-rich greens. Carrot and potato keep insects alive but do nothing for the ratio.

Dusting: two jars, used differently

SUPPLEMENT	HOW
Plain calcium, without vitamin D3	On most insect feedings. This is for the insects, which are calcium-poor
Calcium with vitamin D3	Periodically, not at every feeding. The powder diet already supplies D3, and D3 builds up in the body
Into the powder	Nothing. The complete diet is balanced as sold

Dust just before feeding: shake the insects in a cup or bag with a pinch of powder until they look lightly floured, not caked. An insect left in a dusted container grooms most of it off. If the gecko is under treatment for bone disease, the vet sets the supplement routine.

WHY GUT-LOAD AND DUST BOTH

Gut-loading improves what is inside the insect; dusting adds calcium to the outside. Neither replaces the other, and an insect that is neither is mostly phosphorus with legs.

Treats, the never-feed list & appetite

Treats sit beside the complete diet, and a skipped meal is usually a reason, not a crisis.

FOOD	TIER	WHY
Calcium-rich, low-phosphorus fruit purees	OCCASIONAL	Mashed, beside the powder, in moderation
Avocado	NEVER	Contains persin, a plant toxin documented in birds and mammals rather than reptiles, so this is a precaution. Still never
Citrus fruit	NEVER	Too acidic, and can cause diarrhea
Starfruit, rhubarb	NEVER	High in oxalates, compounds that bind calcium. Rhubarb can be lethal
Garlic, onion, eggplant	NEVER	Unsafe for geckos
Dairy	NEVER	Geckos are lactose intolerant
Wild-caught insects, sugary human food	NEVER	Pesticides and parasites; the wrong nutrients

Why a gargoyle gecko stops eating

REASON	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Shedding	A meal or two skipped in the days before a shed, back to normal after
Breeding season	Males often go off food at its start. Females may stop while gravid or before laying, sometimes a week or more
Stress	A new enclosure, a move, a substrate change, too much handling. It can hold out for weeks while it adjusts
Too cool	A warm side that runs cold slows digestion. Check the basking spot, page 6
Winter slowdown	Less appetite, less climbing, more hiding for a few weeks. Lighter than brumation, the true winter dormancy some reptiles go through, and it needs no deliberate cooling.
Illness	Reduced eating with lesions, a swollen belly, rubbery limbs, breathing trouble or mouth sores

How long is too long

GECKO	WITHOUT FOOD
Healthy, well-hydrated adult	Up to 2 to 3 weeks
Juvenile, still growing	Not past about 4 to 5 days
Sick or already underweight	No more than a few days
Any gecko, without water	No more than 2 to 3 days

SEE A VET IF

It has not eaten in about two weeks and is losing weight. Or appetite loss has lasted about a week alongside any red flag: rapid weight loss (look at the tail first), lethargy, visible lesions, mouth sores, film or swelling over the eyes, labored breathing, or rubbery limbs.

Weight, growth & body condition

Track this gecko in grams. Weight moves before anything else looks wrong.

A gram scale and a small lidded tub are the whole kit. Weigh at the same time of day, before a feeding, and write it on the owner log on page 37. A small amount of natural up and down between weigh-ins is not alarming; a steady slide over several is.

Growth reference

STAGE	WEIGHT	WHAT CHANGES
Hatchling	Under about 12 g	A small grow-out enclosure, paper towel, powder daily. Too fragile and jumpy for routine handling
Growing juvenile	18 to 25 g	The point where a male's bulge appears and sex can be confirmed. Page 20
Reaching maturity	About 35 to 40 g	Around 12 to 18 months. A female is mature at around 40 g
Adult	About 45 to 65 g	Full size, 7 to 9 in (18 to 23 cm) including the tail, depending on sex and genetics. Adult feeding schedule

Maturity comes at around 35 to 40 g, and a fully grown adult runs 45 to 65 g. The spread is the real answer, not a target.

Body condition at a glance

LOSING CONDITION

A thinning tail first, because this gecko stores fat there. Then weight falling across several weigh-ins. Check that the powder is actually eaten, then the warm side, then parasites (page 27).

HOLDING STEADY

A full tail if it has one, weight stable in an adult or climbing steadily in a juvenile, and a firm grip.

GAINING TOO MUCH

Usually too many fatty insects or pinky mice. Obesity in reptiles comes from too little exercise and too many calories, and can lead to fatty liver disease. Cut the treats, not the powder.

The calcium sacs

Geckos store calcium in a pair of small sacs. In this species they sit on the roof of the mouth, at the back of the palate, so they are something a vet checks rather than something you can watch from outside. Healthy sacs look plump and white; shrinking sacs are an early warning of a calcium problem, page 23.

WHEN A WEIGHT CHANGE IS A VET VISIT

Any steady loss across three or four weigh-ins, a juvenile that stops gaining, or a female still losing after she has laid. Bring the owner log: a trend line tells a vet far more than one number.

Handling, the bite & the tail

Calm and slow as an adult. Skittish as a juvenile. Judge the species by the grown animal.

Adult gargoyle geckos are docile and slow-moving, one of the calmer climbing geckos to handle. Young ones are a different animal: skittish, jumpy, and quick to leap at the slightest disturbance. Adults settle considerably as they mature, so do not judge the species by a nervous juvenile.

Getting started

STEP	HOW
Wait	About two weeks after it comes home before any handling
Sessions	Start at 5 minutes every other day , work up to about 15 minutes , and keep total daily handling near 20 minutes even once it is tame
Where	Low, over a bed, couch or close to the floor. A jumpy gecko leaps when startled, and a fall from height is a real injury risk
How	Let it walk onto your hand rather than grabbing it from a hide. Treadmilling, moving one hand in front of the other as it walks, keeps a jumpy one calm
When	During the day, when it is naturally sleepier, tends to go more smoothly than an evening session
After	Back into the enclosure, then wash your hands with soap and running water, page 10

Two defenses worth understanding

The bite. Rare, and almost always provoked. Gargoyle geckos have noticeably larger teeth than crested geckos, so an adult bite can draw blood where a crested gecko's usually cannot break skin. It is still a minor wound: wash it with soap and water.

The tail. Like most geckos, a gargoyle drops its tail if grabbed by it, badly startled or restrained roughly. This is called autotomy, a deliberate break at a built-in weak point. **Never grab or hold the tail.** Unlike a crested gecko, a gargoyle grows it back. The new tail is prehensile (able to grip), with cartilage rather than bone inside and somewhat uneven scales, and it works. A 2024 genome study confirmed the difference: crested geckos have lost the ability to regrow a tail, gargoyles have not.

HANDLING IS NOT ENRICHMENT

For a gecko that drops its tail when stressed, handling is something it tolerates. A gecko that leaps away, thrashes or bites every session is asking for shorter sessions or a break, and a new one gets none at all until it has settled and is eating.

Shedding, seasonal slowdown & behavior

Most of what worries a new owner is normal. This page sorts the normal from the worth-a-look.

The shed cycle

Reptiles shed their outer skin, a process called ecdysis, to grow and to clear old, damaged skin. Juveniles shed far more often than adults because they are growing faster, and there is no universal schedule. What matters is whether each shed comes off cleanly and completely, especially on the toes and the tail tip. The gecko often skips a meal or two in the days before a shed. Humidity is the biggest single factor in a clean shed, and rough surfaces such as cork and textured branches give it something to rub against.

Seasonal slowdown, not brumation

Some reptiles go through brumation, a true winter dormancy. Gargoyle geckos show something lighter: for a few weeks, usually in winter, they eat less, climb less and hide more. It needs no deliberate cooling. Weigh through it. **A slowdown with a steady weight is a season; a slowdown with a falling weight is a health problem**, page 22.

Color, activity and the breeding season

Wild-type gargoyles are light to dark gray with patches of orange or red, in reticulated or striped patterns, and selectively bred lines run from saturated red to white and black. They are sleepier by day and active after dark. Wild gargoyles live surprisingly low for a climbing gecko, mostly within a few meters of the ground, and come down to the forest floor to hide or to cross between plants. Males often go off food at the start of the breeding season.

Normal, or worth a look

NORMAL	WORTH A LOOK
Rarely seeing a shed happen	Shed left on toes or the tail tip: it can strangle a toe. Page 25
Eating less for a few days around a shed	Eating less with weight falling across several weigh-ins. Page 14
Sleeping tucked into cork or leaves all day	Sleeping hanging upside down on bare glass , night after night. Page 24
Using the floor and the low hides	Sitting low and listless after a hot day. Page 26
A regrown tail that looks different	A tail hanging over the back when it rests upside down.
Slower in winter, weight steady	A soft jaw, a wavy tail, trembling. Page 23
Quiet breathing	Open-mouth breathing, clicking, bubbles at the nose.

THE EVENING CHECK

Feeding time is the best health check you have, because the gecko is awake and moving. Clear eyes, a firm grip on the branch, a quick strike at an insect, quiet breathing and clean toes: that takes ten seconds to see and catches most of Section 06 early.

Common mistakes & enrichment

The most common mistake with a climbing gecko is buying a tall enclosure and leaving the top two thirds empty.

The ten mistakes that make this gecko sick

MISTAKE	THE FIX
"No heat needed", and no gradient at all	A low-wattage bulb on a thermostat. Page 6
A basking bulb with no thermostat, or a tank in a sunny window	Air never over 86°F (30°C).
Humidity held high around the clock	A daily dry-back toward 50%. Page 7
An enclosure that never gets misted properly	A heavy evening mist; stuck shed costs toes. Page 25
A tall enclosure with bare glass walls	Branches and cork, floor to top. Page 9
Powder only, no insects	Insects 1 to 2 times a week for adults. Page 11
Insects undusted, or D3 at every feeding	Plain calcium mostly, D3 periodically. Page 13
Two geckos in one enclosure	One per enclosure. Page 20
Grabbing it by the tail, or handling a new arrival	Two weeks to settle, then let it walk on. Page 16
Sand, wood chips or gravel	Coconut fiber, bioactive soil or paper towel.

What helps most

The evidence comes from the gargoyle's closest studied relatives. A study comparing two nocturnal (night-active) gecko species found that **crested geckos which engaged with new objects sooner, and for longer, had lower baseline levels of stress hormones**. That is a link, not proof that novelty calms a gecko, and it is still the best steer available for this group. In leopard geckos, five kinds of enrichment were tested and ranked: **temperature and feeding ranked highest, visual enrichment lowest**.

Priority order

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ 1. Vertical structure it can genuinely climb | ☐ 4. Feeding both ways: powder and hunted insects |
| ☐ 2. Cover available at every height | ☐ 5. Feeding spots placed so it has to climb |
| ☐ 3. Humidity and live planting | ☐ 6. Occasional novelty, last |

FEED BOTH HALVES

Put the powder in shallow dishes at different heights, so getting to food means climbing. Then release live insects into the planting, which is the part a dish cannot do: hunting is what gets removed when everything arrives in a bowl. A new piece of cork or a moved branch now and then is cheap and reasonable.

Choosing a gecko, quarantine & the law

The healthiest gecko is chosen well, kept apart for months and seen by a vet early.

Choosing one

Every gargoyle for sale should be captive-bred. Once among the rarest lizards in captivity, the species is now bred in large numbers, so an animal offered as wild-caught, or with no breeder history at all, is a reason to walk away. Color and pattern set the price, not sex or personality: reticulated gray, black and white is the cheapest, striped and red- or orange-striped run higher, and saturated "super red" or selectively bred white and black lines reach \$500 to \$1,000 or more. Look the gecko over in good light before paying.

CHECK	HEALTHY	WALK AWAY OR ASK MORE
Eyes	Clear and alert	Swollen, sunken, cloudy or crusted
Nose, breathing	Dry nostrils, quiet breathing	Bubbles, mucus, wheezing, open-mouth breathing
Vent	Clean	Stained, pasted with droppings, or swollen
Body	Rounded body, a full tail base	Hips, spine or ribs showing; a thin tail
Skin, shed	Intact, no old shed	Wounds, or rings of old shed on toes or tail tip
Mites	None	Tiny dark, red or orange specks, especially around the eyes

Ask four things: the hatch date, whether it was captive-bred, what it eats and when it last ate, and whether it has been treated for anything. A good breeder answers without looking it up.

Quarantine: three to six months

If you keep any other reptile, the new gecko is kept apart for **3 to 6 months**; 60 to 90 days is only the floor. A **separate room**, not a second tank on the same shelf. Paper towel substrate, so mites, droppings and regurgitated food are visible. Its own dish, tongs and spray bottle. Care for the established animals first and this one last, washing your hands between. Book a first vet exam within 72 hours of bringing it home, and no later than two weeks, with a fecal exam (a microscope check of a fresh dropping for parasites). One clear fecal does not end quarantine. **If anything flags, the clock restarts.**

Where it is legal

Captive-bred gargoyle geckos are legal to keep in most of the United States, and this package carries no state-by-state table. A few rules that cover lizards as a class are worth knowing. Hawaii allows an animal only if it appears on its approved lists and bars anything never written down, so check whether this species is listed before buying there. The District of Columbia permits no lizard as a private pet. Some states tie their gecko clearances to a species' conservation status, and West Virginia requires an importation permit for any reptile brought in from outside the state. Your state wildlife agency is the answer that counts, and a city or county can be stricter than its state.

Sexing, single housing & pairs

One gecko per enclosure, and a pair only when you mean to breed.

Telling male from female

A male grows a clear bulge at the base of the tail, just behind the vent (the single rear opening that droppings and eggs pass through), where the hemipenes, the paired male reproductive organs, sit. A female stays smooth below the vent. **The bulge shows once a male reaches roughly 18 to 25 g**, and that is when sex is confirmed. Femoral pores, a row of small pores in front of the vent, can be checked earlier using a jeweler's loupe (a small magnifier), but a young female can show a slight bulge and a pore reading on a juvenile is not always right.

	MALE	FEMALE
Tail base	A clear bulge behind the vent, from about 18 to 25 g	Smooth
Maturity	Can breed at about a year, if large enough	Later: around 40 g and 12 to 18 months
If bred	Commonly loses its tail during mating	Lays eggs through the season

Why one per enclosure

- **Territorial.** Males fight when housed together.
- **Tail-nipping.** Gargoyles are known for nipping tails in shared enclosures, and juveniles kept together can nip and eat each other's tails.
- **Hatchlings get eaten.** An adult can eat a hatchling.
- **Mating is rough.** Rough enough that a breeding male with a tail at all is unusual. Pairing a small young male with a much larger female invites aggression.
- **Unlike the mourning gecko**, a small gecko kept in colonies, gargoyles are not a colonial species. Solo is the safe default.

Before you house any two together

Both are sexed at a size where the bulge is clear, both have finished quarantine on page 19, and you have a plan for the eggs and the hatchlings, which need their own tubs. Two females do not avoid the egg question: a lone female can still produce eggs.

GARGOYLE OR CRESTED, SIDE BY SIDE

Gargoyle: regrows its tail, bite can break skin, climbs glass poorly and needs branches, juveniles jumpier, insects required. Crested: tail gone for good, bite rarely breaks skin, sticks to glass with ease, insects optional. Same islands, same powder, different animals.

Females, eggs & egg binding

A female kept alone can still produce eggs. This page is for every female owner, not only breeders.

Eggs without a male

A single female with no exposure to a male can still become gravid, carrying eggs. That is why most reptiles brought to a vet for egg binding are single females. A gravid female may refuse food and still be bright and active, which is normal; a female that is off food and also weak is not.

What a breeding female does

FACT	FIGURE
Clutch	Usually 2 eggs, one from each ovary
Clutches a season	4 to 5, about 4.5 to 6 weeks apart
Where she lays	She buries them, so she needs a lidded laying box of damp substrate with an entry hole cut in the top
Incubation	Room temperature around 70°F (21°C) with no added heat; hatching about 70 to 90 days after laying
Hatchlings	Small tubs of their own, with a humid hide and climbing foliage. Never back in with adults
Laying years	Females produce eggs for about 6 years

Egg binding: when she cannot lay

Cause: egg binding, called dystocia, is a female unable to pass her eggs. Poor husbandry is often behind it: no suitable place to lay, wrong temperatures, humidity or lighting, too little calcium. Age, injury, infection and oversized or misshapen eggs also play a part. **Signs:** a gravid female that has stopped eating and is weak, with a swollen belly. Many cases progress to severe lethargy, and the gecko can become unresponsive if it is not treated early. Unlike in mammals and birds, it is rarely sudden: eggs can be held for weeks or even months past the normal laying time. **Diagnosis:** a reptile vet, by feeling the belly and with x-rays and blood tests that tell egg binding apart from a normal pregnancy. **Treatment:** fluids, calcium and hormone injections at doses the vet sets, a quiet, private nest site, and in many cases surgery to remove the eggs. For a single female, the vet may suggest spaying, surgically removing the ovaries. **Recovery:** early treatment improves the outcome; waiting makes surgery more likely.

SAME-DAY CALL

A female heavy with eggs that is off food and weak, straining with nothing produced, or with any tissue showing at the vent. Do not wait to see whether she lays overnight.

PREVENTION

Correct temperatures, humidity and UVB, enough calcium in the diet, water every day, and a laying box in place before she needs it. Weigh a laying female before and after each clutch, and raise clutch after clutch with the vet rather than accepting it as normal.

Health red flags & finding a vet

Most of this section traces back to two husbandry errors: humidity that never cycles, held too wet or too dry around the clock, or an enclosure without enough places to hide.

CALL A REPTILE VET TODAY IF

The air has passed 86°F (30°C) and the gecko is weak, limp or unresponsive. Open-mouth breathing, mucus or bubbles at the nose, clicking or wheezing. A soft jaw, a kinked or wavy tail, curved limbs, or tremors. A gravid female off food and weak. Any tissue showing at the vent. A toe that has turned dark or is tightly ringed with old shed. No water access for 2 to 3 days.

BOOK THIS WEEK IF

Weight falling across several weigh-ins, or a thinning tail. Not eating for about two weeks with weight loss, or about a week alongside any other sign. Loose, smelly droppings more than once. A tail still bending over the back after you have added branches and hides. Film or swelling over the eyes. Yellow, orange or gritty urates.

Finding the right vet

Not every practice treats reptiles. The ARAV (Association of Reptile and Amphibian Veterinarians) runs a find-a-vet directory, and the vet should at least be a member. When you call, ask how many reptiles the practice sees, whether it runs fecal exams in house, and who covers reptile emergencies after hours. A routine exotic exam runs about **\$50 to \$150**; an illness visit with tests, **\$150 to \$600**; imaging or surgery, **\$800 to \$2,500 or more**. These are general exotic reptile figures.

What to bring

BRING	WHY
The gecko, in a ventilated tub	On paper towel, inside a dark bag or box. Page 35
Your readings	Both temperatures, the highest the enclosure reached recently, and both humidity readings
The owner log	Weights, feedings, droppings and sheds, page 37. A trend tells the vet more than one number
A fresh dropping	In a sealed bag, for a fecal exam
Photos and the diet	The enclosure, the powder brand, the supplement jars and the UVB tube's install date

DO NOTHING CLEVER BEFORE THE APPOINTMENT

No home medication and no supplement changes. Keep the gecko in its normal temperature range on paper towel, with water and a misted surface, and get it seen. Medication doses are always set by the vet for the individual animal.

Metabolic bone disease

A calcium problem, and one this species may develop earlier than a crested gecko.

Metabolic bone disease, MBD for short, is the everyday name for nutritional secondary hyperparathyroidism: when the diet runs short of usable calcium, the body pulls calcium out of the skeleton to keep the blood level up, and the bones soften and bend. Gargoyle geckos may be more prone to early MBD than crested geckos, which is why the supplement routine on page 13 matters so much.

MBD

Cause	Too little calcium or vitamin D3, often with no UVB. In practice: powder that is served but not eaten, insects fed without dusting or gut-loading, a calcium-to-phosphorus balance tipped the wrong way, or a UVB tube long past its date. Too cool an enclosure plays a part too
Signs	A kinked or wavy tail, a soft or rubbery jaw, curved limbs, tremors or twitching, loss of coordination, lethargy and appetite loss. Advanced cases bring a swollen or distorted jaw, broken bones and a cloacal prolapse (tissue pushed out of the vent).
Diagnosis	A vet: blood tests for calcium and vitamin D3, x-rays to show how dense the bones are, and a look at the calcium sacs at the back of the roof of the mouth. Bring the supplement jars and the UVB tube's install date
Treatment	Correcting the diet and husbandry is the core of it, with fluids, nutritional support and calcium as the vet directs. Any calcium or vitamin D3 dosing during treatment is set by the vet
Recovery	Early cases often resolve within months once diet and supplements are corrected, and the outlook is best while the gecko is still eating. Deformities already present are usually permanent

A SOFT JAW IS A VET VISIT, NOT A SUPPLEMENT CHANGE

A jaw that feels soft, any tremor, or a gecko that has stopped climbing when it used to is an appointment this week rather than something to watch. Meanwhile lower the highest perches so a weak gecko cannot fall from height.

Prevention is three habits

- **A complete powder that is actually eaten**, not just served. Check the dish, page 12.
- **Insects gut-loaded and dusted**, plain calcium on most feedings and D3 periodically.
- **Low-level UVB**, replaced on schedule, page 8.

MORE IS NOT SAFER

Vitamin D3 builds up in the body, and the powder already carries it. Dusting D3 on every insect, or stirring supplements into the powder, does not prevent bone disease any better, and a vet should set any change while a gecko is being treated.

Floppy tail syndrome & tail loss

Two very different tail problems. One is caused by the enclosure; the other is a defense.

FLOPPY TAIL	FLOPPY TAIL SYNDROME (FTS)
Cause	Repeatedly sleeping hanging upside down on bare glass, which over time deforms the base of the tail. A gargoyle grips glass poorly, and in a sparse enclosure the glass is all it has
Signs	The tail hangs over the gecko's back, or flops to one side, when it rests upside down
Why it matters	Over time it can deform the base of the tail and the hips, which can make it hard for the gecko to pass droppings or, in a female, lay eggs
Diagnosis	A reptile vet confirms it, and checks for a calcium problem behind it, since bone disease also affects the tail
Treatment	Almost entirely the enclosure: enough branches, cork and hides that the gecko stops choosing the glass. Severe cases may need the vet to remove the tail to stop the spine and hips deforming further
Recovery	Caught early, clutter stops it getting worse. A tail that stays bent after you have added hides and branches is a vet visit

THE PREVENTION TEST

Look at where the gecko sleeps. If it is in a cork tube, behind a leaf or on a branch, the enclosure is doing its job. If it is flat on the glass, upside down, night after night, it needs more clutter at the top, today. Page 9.

Tail loss, and the tail that grows back

TAIL DROP	AUTOTOMY
Cause	A defense, not a disease. The gecko drops its tail if grabbed by it, badly startled, restrained roughly, or in a fight. Mating is rough enough that breeding males often have no tail at all
Signs	A dropped tail and a break at the tail base
Response	Put the gecko back in a clean, quiet enclosure and leave it alone. A stump that swells, oozes or smells goes to the vet
Recovery	Unlike a crested gecko, a gargoyle regrows its tail. The new one is prehensile, with cartilage rather than bone, and somewhat uneven scales, and it works

DO NOT CONFUSE THE TWO

A dropped tail is a stress response with a good outcome. A bent tail is a husbandry problem with a slow, poor outcome if nothing changes. The first needs calmer handling; the second needs more branches.

Stuck shed, toe loss & respiratory infection

The two opposite humidity mistakes. Too dry costs toes; too wet costs lungs.

STUCK SHED	DYSECDYSIS (A BAD SHED), AND TOE OR TAIL-TIP LOSS
Cause	Mostly low humidity: the most common gargoyle husbandry failure. Mites, poor nutrition, illness and nothing rough to rub against can also cause it
Signs	Rings or patches of old skin left on the toes or the tail tip after a shed. Left on, the ring tightens like a tourniquet and cuts off blood flow until the toe dies and drops off
Response	Early stuck shed often softens with a gentle warm soak: shallow, chin-deep water at enclosure temperature for about 30 minutes, supervised the whole time, then rub it off gently with a damp cotton swab. Never peel dry shed. A tight band you cannot shift, or a toe that has turned dark, goes to the vet
Recovery	A lost toe is gone for good. Prevention is the daily wet-dry cycle on page 7, with a heavy evening mist, not a permanently damp tank
RESPIRATORY	RESPIRATORY INFECTION
Cause	An enclosure kept constantly wet with poor ventilation, the opposite mistake from stuck shed. Too cool a setup, dirty conditions and other illness add to the risk
Signs	Labored or open-mouth breathing, mucus or bubbles around the nose, a clicking or wheezing sound, lethargy and appetite loss
Diagnosis	A vet, who may take a sample to grow and identify the bacteria so the right antibiotic is chosen
Treatment	Antibiotics prescribed by the vet, with the gecko kept toward the warm part of its normal range and the husbandry fixed at the same time: humidity dropping back between mistings, and real airflow
Recovery	It can be fatal if untreated, and a long, untreated case can spread into the blood. Fixing the humidity and airflow is part of every recovery

BREATHING TROUBLE IS A SAME-DAY CALL

Open-mouth breathing, bubbles at the nose or a clicking sound is a vet call today, not a wait-and-see. Do not raise the heat past the normal basking range to "help": this species' ceiling is 86°F (30°C) whatever is wrong.

ONE HYGROMETER, TWO PROBLEMS PREVENTED

Both conditions are settings, not bad luck. Read the hygrometer an hour after the evening mist and again the next afternoon. A high reading that never drops points at respiratory infection; a low reading that never climbs points at stuck shed.

Overheating, dehydration & reading droppings

The emergency this gecko's low ceiling creates, and the free health check in the droppings.

Overheating

Air above 86°F (30°C) is dangerous for this species. The usual causes are sun on the glass, a bulb with no thermostat or a thermostat that has failed, and a room that got away from you in a heat wave. Act on the thermometer rather than waiting for the gecko to look unwell.

IF THE READING IS OVER 86°F (30°C)	DO THIS
First	Turn the heat source off and get the enclosure out of any sun
Then	Cool the room: shade the window, open the screen top fully, run a fan across the room rather than into the enclosure. Mist the surfaces so there are droplets to drink
If the gecko is weak, limp or unresponsive	Move it in a ventilated tub with a damp paper towel to the coolest room, and call the vet now
Afterward	Find what did it, and fix that before the heat goes back on. Page 35 has the heat-wave plan

Dehydration

Signs of dehydration in a reptile include loose skin and sunken eyes. Because this gecko drinks mostly from misted surfaces, a missed evening mist matters more than a stale dish. Correct the misting and check the hygrometer. A gecko whose skin stays loose once the cycle is right needs a vet, who can give fluids by injection.

Reading the droppings

A reptile passes solid stool and urates together: the urate is the white, chalky paste of uric acid, the reptile version of urine.

IT LOOKS LIKE	USUALLY MEANS	DO
A formed dropping with a smooth white to cream urate. Softer than a pure insect-eater's, because of the fruit-based powder	Normal	Note it in the log and carry on
Watery or unformed more than once in a row, or very smelly	Parasites, often protozoa (single-celled parasites)	Fresh sample in a sealed bag, book a fecal exam.
Blood, bright red or dark and tarry	Bleeding in the gut or near the vent	Vet
Straining to pass anything	A blockage, a vent problem, or egg binding in a female	Vet. Page 21
Urate yellow, orange or gritty	Dehydration, and left uncorrected a urate or kidney problem that can lead to gout (uric acid crystals in joints or organs)	More misting first: for a climbing gecko the fix is droplets, not a bigger bowl. Persisting is a vet visit

Parasites, blockages, mouth rot & more

Less common, and still worth recognizing early.

PARASITES	INTERNAL PARASITES
Cause	Worms and protozoa (single-celled parasites), most often arriving with a new animal
Signs	Often none at first. Then weight loss despite eating, repeated loose or smelly droppings, and a gecko that fails to thrive
Diagnosis	A fecal exam on a fresh sample. That is why every new gecko gets one inside quarantine, page 19
Treatment and recovery	Medication chosen and dosed by the vet, treated only when the exam finds a real burden, with daily cleaning of droppings while it works

Cryptosporidiosis, a protozoal gut infection known in other geckos, causes marked weight loss and slow wasting, is diagnosed with a special stain on fresh droppings, and has no reliably effective treatment. It is the strongest argument for the full quarantine window.

BLOCKAGE	IMPACTION
Cause	A gut blockage, linked to swallowing substrate along with food. The risk sits with sand, wood chips and gravel rather than with soil or coconut fiber, and a climbing gecko that lives off the floor is at lower risk than a ground-dweller
Signs	Straining, a swollen belly, or no droppings for longer than its normal pattern, with appetite loss
Response and recovery	A vet. Switch to paper towel meanwhile. Recovery depends on what is blocking and how it is cleared

MOUTH ROT	INFECTIOUS STOMATITIS
Cause	A bacterial infection of the mouth and gums
Signs	Tiny purplish-red spots inside the mouth at first, then cheesy material building up along the rows of teeth. Mouth sores often come with appetite loss
Response and recovery	A vet visit, without waiting: severe cases can spread into the jawbone

PROLAPSE	TISSUE PUSHED OUT OF THE VENT
Cause	The cloaca (the shared chamber behind the vent), the colon, the oviduct (egg tube) in a female or a hemipenis in a male can be pushed out. Causes include egg binding, rough mating, infection, bone disease and straining
Signs	Tissue showing at the vent that does not go back in
Response and recovery	A same-day vet call. Keep the gecko on clean paper towel so the tissue picks up no substrate. Outcome follows the cause and how fast it is treated

MITES, AND WHY PAPER TOWEL HELPS

Lizard mites show as tiny orange, red or dark specks, often around the eyes, and are hard to see in small numbers. For any gecko under watch, plain paper towel shows every mite, dropping and leftover insect, and lets you tell a vet exactly what came out and when.

Setup checklist & targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ 18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) arboreal enclosure with a screen top; 24×24×24 in (61×61×61 cm) preferred
- ☐ Low-wattage basking bulb or ceramic heat emitter, in a dome outside the screen
- ☐ Thermostat, with its probe at gecko level
- ☐ Digital thermometer and hygrometer, read high and low
- ☐ 12 in (30 cm) low-output T5 HO UVB tube and hood, on a 12 hour timer
- ☐ Coconut fiber, bioactive soil mix, or paper towel
- ☐ Branches, vines and cork bark, generously, floor to top
- ☐ Live or artificial plants at every height
- ☐ Fine mist spray bottle, a shallow water dish and a feeding ledge
- ☐ Complete powdered diet, three or more flavors
- ☐ Gut-loaded feeder insects, plain calcium, and calcium with D3
- ☐ A gram scale and a small lidded tub to weigh in

Targets

TARGET	°F	°C
Cool end, low	70 to 75	21 to 24
Basking spot, high	82 to 85	28 to 29
Night	low 70s, or down to the mid-60s	about 18 to 23
Never above, anywhere	86	30
Never below, anywhere	65	18
Humidity	50 to 70% average: heavy evening mist, dry back toward 50% before the next	
UVB	Basking-area UVI about 1.0 to 2.0; replace the tube every 6 to 12 months	
Light cycle	12 hours on, 12 hours off, nothing overnight	
Powder	Juveniles daily; adults every 2 to 3 days	
Insects	Juveniles and adults 1 to 2 times a week; plain calcium on most	
Water	Never more than 2 to 3 days without access	

Before your gecko comes home

- ☐ Enclosure running for a few days, with the gradient and the wet-dry cycle both verified
- ☐ Reptile vet found, and a first exam booked within 72 hours
- ☐ Quarantine room and tub ready if another reptile lives in the house
- ☐ A plan for keeping the room under 86°F (30°C) in the hottest week

Emergency & quick targets

CALL THE REPTILE VET NOW IF

The air has passed 86°F (30°C) and the gecko is weak, limp or unresponsive. Open-mouth breathing, mucus or bubbles at the nose, clicking or wheezing. A soft jaw, kinked or wavy tail, curved limbs or tremors. A gravid female off food and weak, or straining. Any tissue showing at the vent. A toe gone dark or ringed tight with old shed.

READING	°F	°C
Cool end, low	70 to 75	21 to 24
Basking spot, high	82 to 85	28 to 29
Act above, anywhere	86	30
Act below, anywhere	65	18
Humidity	50 to 70% average, drying back toward 50% before the next mist	
Water	Never more than 2 to 3 days without access	

WHILE YOU WAIT FOR THE VET

Keep the gecko in a ventilated tub on paper towel, at its normal temperature, with a misted surface to drink from. If it overheated, turn the heat off and move it to the coolest room. No home medication and no supplement changes.

Your numbers

Reptile vet _____

Last weight, in grams _____

24-hour exotic emergency clinic _____

UVB tube installed _____

Gecko's name and hatch date _____

Last vet visit _____

Routine, written down

Powder days _____

Misting times _____

Insect days and dusting _____

Lights on and off at _____

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

What you saw and when it started. Today's weight and the last three from the log. Both temperatures, the highest the enclosure has reached recently, and both humidity readings. When it last ate powder and insects, and last passed a dropping. Bring a fresh dropping in a sealed bag, photos of the setup, and the owner log.

SECTION 08 · OWNER TOOLS

Budget & shopping list

United States retail ranges, last checked October 2026 and rounded to the nearest \$5. The low end is basic but correct gear; the high end is premium.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
Arboreal enclosure, 18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) minimum; check the dimensions before you buy	\$100 to \$200
Low-output UVB hood with a 5.0 (5%) T5 HO tube, about two-thirds the enclosure length (check the length against your enclosure)	\$45 to \$75
Low-wattage heat bulb and dome fixture, 25 to 40 watts	\$20 to \$40
Dimming thermostat	\$30 to \$35
Digital thermometer and hygrometer	\$15 to \$25
Coconut fiber or bioactive substrate	\$20 to \$40
Cork bark and branches	\$20 to \$60
Live or artificial plants	\$25 to \$45
Misting bottle	\$5 to \$15
Shallow water dish	\$5 to \$15
Magnetic feeding ledge	\$10 to \$20
First bag of complete powdered diet, 8 oz (227 g)	\$20 to \$30
First supply of plain calcium and calcium with D3	\$25 to \$45
Gram scale and a small lidded tub to weigh in	\$10 to \$15
Setup, every row added up	\$350 to \$660
First vet exam	\$50 to \$150
With the first vet exam, before the gecko	\$400 to \$810
The gecko, common reticulated or striped, captive-bred	\$50 to \$300
All in, gecko home and checked	\$450 to \$1,110

Highly recommended, not in the total: a UV index meter, about \$240 to \$265, the only way to check the UVB tube's height and when it needs replacing; UV cards do not measure UVB.

A premium color line costs \$500 to \$1,000 or more instead of the gecko line above, which puts the all-in figure at roughly \$900 to \$1,810. A UVB tube's wattage is not its length: a slim high-output tube of 24 watts is about 22 in (56 cm) long, 39 watts about 34 in (86 cm), 54 watts about 46 in (117 cm). Match the length in inches to two-thirds of the enclosure.

Budget: yearly costs

What a gargoyle gecko costs to keep each year once the setup on the previous page is in place, on the same rounding.

YEARLY ONGOING	TYPICAL COST
Complete powdered diet, six 8 oz bags (each lasts an adult about two months)	\$120 to \$170
Dubia roaches and crickets	\$70 to \$130
Supplement top-ups	\$15 to \$25
UVB tube replacement, budgeted every 6 months (two a year)	\$40 to \$45
Electricity, lighting	\$25 to \$45
Annual vet wellness check	\$50 to \$150
Yearly total	\$320 to \$565

Food and supplements run about \$15 to \$30 a month. A complete powdered diet already carries its vitamins, so no separate multivitamin is needed. Substrate replacement goes on top for a non-bioactive setup. Retail prices move, so treat these tables as a snapshot, not a quote.

PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

An illness visit with tests runs \$150 to \$600, and imaging or surgery \$800 to \$2,500 or more. A few hundred dollars set aside matters as much as any line here.

OVER A WHOLE LIFE

At \$320 to \$565 a year for 15 to 20 years, this gecko costs roughly \$4,800 to \$11,300 in routine care after setup, before a single emergency.

First 30 days

The first month sets the habits. Quarantine, if you keep other reptiles, runs well past it.

Day 1

- ☐ Move the gecko in a ventilated tub, then straight into the running enclosure
- ☐ Weigh it in a lidded tub for a baseline, and start page 37
- ☐ Fill in the emergency card, page 29
- ☐ Start the equipment dates, page 38
- ☐ Evening mist, powder in the dish, lights to timer, and leave it alone

Days 2 to 3

- ☐ First vet exam within 72 hours, with a fecal exam
- ☐ Offer powder on the normal schedule even if it goes untouched

Week 1

- ☐ No handling. Read the hygrometer an hour after the evening mist and the next afternoon
- ☐ Check both thermometers daily, and the highest reading of the day
- ☐ Note where it sleeps: on cork or a branch, not upside down on the glass

Week 2

- ☐ First insect feeding once it is eating powder: gut-loaded, dusted with plain calcium
- ☐ Weigh again and compare with day 1
- ☐ Settle the powder days and insect days, and write them on page 29

Weeks 3 and 4

- ☐ First short handling sessions, 5 minutes every other day, low over a bed, page 16
- ☐ Check toes and tail tip after the first shed you notice
- ☐ Adjust the humidity if it is not drying back toward 50%
- ☐ Fill in the pet-sitter sheet, page 36, before you need it
- ☐ Act on the fecal result rather than filing it

After day 30

- ☐ Quarantine continues for 3 to 6 months if another reptile lives in the house, page 19

A QUIET FIRST MONTH IS A GOOD FIRST MONTH

A new gecko that hides by day, eats a little at night and holds its weight is doing everything right. Early food refusals are common while it adjusts. The things to watch for are the red flags on page 22, not a lack of activity.

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Weak, limp or unresponsive after a hot spell	Overheating	Heat off, coolest room, vet now (page 26)
Open-mouth breathing, bubbles at the nose, clicking	Respiratory infection	Vet today; let the humidity dry back, more airflow (page 25)
Rings of old skin on toes or tail tip	Stuck shed, from low humidity	Warm soak, damp swab; vet if it will not shift (page 25)
A toe turned dark	Blood flow cut off by stuck shed	Vet; fix the misting (page 25)
Soft jaw, wavy tail, curved limbs, tremors	Metabolic bone disease	Vet this week; lower the perches (page 23)
Tail hangs over the back when upside down	Floppy tail syndrome	More branches and cork; vet if it stays (page 24)
Tail dropped	Fright, rough handling, a fall	Quiet, clean enclosure; it regrows (page 24)
Thin tail, weight falling	Underfeeding, parasites, illness	Check the powder is eaten; fecal exam (page 15)
Loose, smelly droppings more than once	Parasites	Fresh sample to the vet (page 27)
Straining, swollen belly, no droppings	Blockage, or egg binding in a female	Vet; paper towel meanwhile (page 27)
Female off food, weak, belly swollen	Egg binding	Vet today (page 21)
Tissue showing at the vent	Prolapse	Vet today; clean paper towel (page 27)
Red spots or cheesy material in the mouth	Mouth rot	Vet (page 27)
Loose skin, sunken eyes	Dehydration	Fix the evening mist; vet if it persists (page 26)
Yellow, orange or gritty urates	Dehydration, then a kidney problem	More misting; vet if it persists (page 26)
Eating less, weight steady, in winter	Seasonal slowdown	Weigh weekly; no cooling needed (page 17)
Not eating, with the setup in range	Shed, stress, breeding season, or illness	Thresholds on page 14
Tiny orange, red or dark specks	Mites	Paper towel, vet (page 27)

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Heavy mist in the evening as the gecko wakes
- ☐ Empty, wash and refill the water dish
- ☐ Remove droppings, urates, shed skin and leftover food
- ☐ Read both thermometers and the hygrometer
- ☐ Juveniles: fresh powder

Every 2 to 3 days

- ☐ Adults: fresh powder, uneaten diet out within 24 to 48 hours

Weekly

- ☐ Insects: once or twice, adults and juveniles alike, gut-loaded and dusted
- ☐ Weigh, and log it
- ☐ Replace soiled substrate in sections; wipe the glass
- ☐ Check toes and tail tip after any shed

Monthly

- ☐ Full strip-down and disinfect, unless bioactive
- ☐ Check every branch and cork piece is anchored
- ☐ Look at where it sleeps: no hanging on bare glass
- ☐ Move a branch or add a piece of cork for novelty

Every 6 to 12 months

- ☐ Replace the UVB tube on the maker's schedule, even if it still lights

Yearly

- ☐ Wellness exam with a fecal test
- ☐ Supplements past their date replaced

Seasonal

- ☐ Summer: enclosure out of the sun, and a plan to keep it under 86°F (30°C)
- ☐ Winter: night low against 65°F (18°C), and weigh through any slowdown

WHAT A GOOD WEEK LOOKS LIKE

The basking spot at 82 to 85°F (28 to 29°C) and the cool end at 70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C), with nothing ever over 86°F (30°C). The hygrometer high after the evening mist and back toward 50% by the next evening. A gecko that sleeps tucked into cork by day, climbs to its ledge at night, and holds its weight.

IF YOU ONLY KEEP ONE HABIT

Weigh it. A gram scale often shows a problem before the gecko looks unwell, and a column of steady numbers is the best thing you can hand a vet.

Heat waves, power outages, travel & transport

The two edges are 65°F (18°C) and 86°F (30°C). For this gecko the hot edge is the closer one.

When it gets too hot

- Turn the heat source off first. In a heat wave the room is the heater.
- Get the enclosure out of any sun and away from exterior walls, to the coolest room in the house.
- More air: open the screen top fully, and run a fan across the room, not into the enclosure.
- Mist the surfaces so there are droplets to drink, and keep the dish full.
- Air past 86°F (30°C) with a gecko that is weak or limp: coolest room, ventilated tub, and call the vet.

When the power goes out

- A battery thermometer where the gecko sits. Act if it is heading below 65°F (18°C).
- Drape thick towels over the enclosure, leaving a vent gap, to hold in the heat that is left.
- Or move the gecko in a ventilated tub to the warmest room, usually one without exterior walls.
- A wrapped hand warmer or hot water bottle beside the tub, **never touching the gecko**.
- No candles, gas stove or open flame near it. Hold off on insects until warmth is back.
- More than a day or two below 65°F (18°C): board it with a vet or a friend who has power.

Leaving town

TRIP	ADULT	JUVENILE
1 to 2 nights	A sitter once a day for the evening mist, the dish and a temperature check. Lights and heat on timers and the thermostat	A sitter daily, with powder made fresh
3 to 7 nights	A sitter daily, with written powder and insect days	A sitter daily
Over a week	A daily sitter who has done a practice visit with you, or boarding with a reptile vet. Never a general dog and cat boarding facility	

One tier stricter than a desert reptile, because misting is a daily job for this gecko. A summer trip also needs the room plan: whoever visits should know the 86°F (30°C) limit.

Transport and vet trips

- A ventilated plastic tub with paper towel to grip, no loose substrate and no water dish to slosh, inside a dark bag or box.
- In cold weather warm the car first, and on a trip over about 30 minutes below 65°F (18°C) add a wrapped hand warmer beside the tub, not touching it. In hot weather cool the car first and keep the tub out of the sun.
- Check the tub every 20 to 30 minutes at a stop. Never leave the gecko in a parked car, hot or cold.

KIT, PACKED BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Two hand warmers, two thick towels, a battery thermometer, a ventilated tub with paper towel, a full spray bottle, and the vet and emergency clinic numbers on paper, not only in a phone that might die.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE ENCLOSURE

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through it once in person before the first solo visit.

Gecko's name _____

Age and normal look _____

My phone _____

Reptile vet _____

24-hour emergency clinic _____

Backup contact _____

Each visit

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ In the evening, mist the leaves, cork and glass until they bead. Not the gecko | ☐ On powder days, mix fresh and put it on the ledge; take out the old |
| ☐ Empty, wash and refill the water dish | ☐ Pick up droppings and leftover food |
| ☐ Read both thermometers and the hygrometer, and write them down | ☐ Wash your hands with soap after, away from the gecko. Nothing goes in the kitchen sink |

Feeding while I'm away

Powder days and amount _____

Which dust, and when _____

Insect days and how many _____

Where everything is kept _____

Normal readings

Basking spot, high	82 to 85°F (28 to 29°C)
Cool end, low	70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C)
Humidity	High after the evening mist, back toward 50% by the next evening

Please don't

- Pick the gecko up, and never touch or hold its tail. If it gets out, let it walk onto your hand, low to the floor.
- Change any dial, timer or thermostat, open the blinds onto the enclosure, or move it into a sunny spot.
- Feed anything not on this sheet, or spray any cleaner or air freshener in this room.

CALL ME IF

Any reading over 86°F (30°C) or under 65°F (18°C): turn the heat off first if it is hot. Open-mouth breathing or bubbles at the nose. The gecko is limp, weak or not gripping. Anything is showing at the vent. It has escaped. If I don't answer, call the vet number above.

Owner log

One row a week. Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	POWDER EATEN	INSECTS, DUST	BASKING / COOL °F OR °C	HUMIDITY HIGH / LOW	SHED, TOES	DROPPINGS, NOTES

Insects, dust: the count, then **P** for plain calcium or **D** for calcium with D3. Humidity: the reading an hour after the evening mist, and the next afternoon's. Shed, toes: a tick if toes and tail tip came out clean.

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

For this gecko the weight column is the early warning system: a slow slide shows up there weeks before a thin tail does. Sixteen rows is four months, long enough to see a real trend rather than a bad week, and it is the first thing a vet will want to see.

Equipment & vet log

Equipment log

ITEM	INSTALLED OR OPENED	REPLACE OR CHECK BY	DONE
UVB tube (every 6 to 12 months)			
Thermostat (check against a thermometer daily)			
Heat bulb			
Thermometer and hygrometer batteries			
Substrate (monthly, unless bioactive)			
Diet powder bags (date opened)			
Calcium and calcium with D3 (replace when out of date)			

Twelve-month planner

Tick the box in the month you did it. Start with whichever month you're in.

TASK	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7	M8	M9	M10	M11	M12
Strip-down and disinfect	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Perches checked for anchoring	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Sleeping spot checked	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
UVB tube	☐						☐					
Vet exam and fecal test	☐											☐

M1 to M12 mean months one to twelve, starting from whichever month you begin.

The UVB row is ticked at 6 months here; move it to month 12 if your tube's maker allows the longer interval.

Vet visit log

DATE	REASON	FINDINGS AND TESTS	TREATMENT, FOLLOW-UP

Quarantine record

Arrived _____

Fecal results _____

From _____

Cleared on _____

Glossary, A to H

Arboreal	Living off the ground, climbing. Why the enclosure is measured in height. Page 5.
ARAV	The Association of Reptile and Amphibian Veterinarians, which runs a find-a-vet directory. Page 22.
Autotomy	Dropping the tail on purpose at a built-in weak point, as a defense. A gargoyle's tail grows back. Page 24.
Bioactive	A living, planted substrate over a drainage layer, with a cleanup crew that breaks down waste. Page 9.
Black soldier fly larvae	A feeder insect whose hard outer shell carries real calcium, unlike most feeders. Page 13.
Brumation	A true winter dormancy some reptiles go through. Gargoyles show only a lighter seasonal slowdown. Page 17.
Calcium sacs	A gecko's calcium stores, described in this species at the back of the roof of the mouth. Shrinking sacs warn of a calcium problem. Page 15.
Ceramic heat emitter	A bulb-shaped heater that gives off heat and no light. Always on a thermostat. Page 6.
Cloaca	The shared chamber behind the vent that droppings, urates and eggs pass through. Page 27.
Complete powdered diet	A commercial powder mixed with water that carries protein, fruit, calcium and vitamin D3 in one food. Page 12.
Cryptosporidiosis	A protozoal gut infection that causes wasting and has no reliably effective treatment. Page 27.
Dechlorinated water	Tap water treated to remove its chlorine. Page 7.
Dysecdysis	A bad or incomplete shed: old skin left behind, often on toes and the tail tip. Page 25.
Dystocia	Egg binding: a female unable to pass her eggs. Page 21.
Ecdysis	Shedding: how a reptile replaces its outer skin. Page 17.
Ectothermic	Running at the temperature of its surroundings, and warming or cooling by moving. Why a gradient matters. Page 6.
Exoskeleton	The hard outer shell of an insect. Page 13.
Fecal exam	A microscope check of a fresh dropping for parasites. Page 19.
Femoral pores	A row of small pores in front of the vent, used as an early, unreliable sexing clue. Page 20.
Floppy tail syndrome (FTS)	A tail that bends over the back, from sleeping upside down on bare glass. It can deform the hips. Page 24.
Gout	Uric acid crystals building up in joints or organs, linked to dehydration and too much protein. Page 26.
Gravid	Carrying eggs. A lone female can be gravid. Page 21.
Gut-loading	Feeding insects a high-calcium diet for 24 to 48 hours before they go to the gecko. Page 13.
Hemipenes	The paired male reproductive organs, which make the bulge behind a male's vent. Page 20.
Hygrometer	A humidity meter. Read it an hour after the evening mist and the next afternoon. Page 7.

Glossary, I to Z

Impaction	A gut blockage, linked to swallowing sand, wood chips or gravel with food. Page 27.
IUCN	The International Union for Conservation of Nature, whose Red List rates this species Least Concern. Page 4.
Jeweler's loupe	A small magnifier, used to look for femoral pores. Page 20.
Metabolic bone disease (MBD)	Soft, bending bones from too little usable calcium, vitamin D3 or UVB; formally nutritional secondary hyperparathyroidism. Page 23.
Nocturnal	Active at night. Why misting, feeding and the daily health check happen in the evening. Page 18.
Oviduct	The egg tube in a female, one of the tissues that can prolapse. Page 27.
Oxalates	Plant compounds that bind calcium, the reason starfruit and rhubarb are never fed. Page 14.
Persin	A plant toxin in avocado. Page 14.
Prehensile	Able to grip. A gargoyle's regrown tail is prehensile. Page 16.
Prolapse	Tissue pushed out through the vent that does not go back in. A same-day vet call. Page 27.
Protozoa	Single-celled parasites, a common cause of loose droppings. Page 27.
Quarantine	Keeping a new gecko in a separate room for 3 to 6 months before it shares air or tools with another reptile. Page 19.
Reticulated	Net-patterned: the gray, black and white wild-type look, and the cheapest. Page 19.
<i>Salmonella</i>	A bacterium healthy reptiles carry without illness, which causes diarrhea, fever and cramps in people. Page 10.
Springtails and isopods	Tiny soil animals and woodlice used as a bioactive cleanup crew. Page 9.
Stomatitis	Mouth rot, a bacterial infection of the mouth and gums. Page 27.
T5 HO	A slim fluorescent tube, 5/8 inch across, in the high output (HO) format; the usual UVB source. A low strength, such as a 5.0 (about 5%), keeps it gentle. Page 8.
Thermostat	A controller that switches or dims the heat source to hold a set temperature, so it cannot overheat the enclosure. Page 6.
Treadmilling	Letting a gecko walk from one hand onto the other placed in front of it, over and over. Page 16.
Units	°F, degrees Fahrenheit, and °C, degrees Celsius, for temperature; in (inches) and cm (centimeters) for size; g (grams) and oz (ounces) for weight; % (percent) for humidity.
Urates	The white, chalky paste in a reptile's droppings: uric acid, the reptile version of urine. Yellow or gritty urates mean dehydration. Page 26.
UV index (UVI)	The standard scale for UVB strength at a point. About 1.0 to 2.0 at this gecko's basking area. Page 8.
UVB	Ultraviolet B, the band of ultraviolet light that lets a gecko make vitamin D3. Optional for this species, and worth having. Page 8.
Vent	The single rear opening that droppings, urates and eggs pass through. Page 20.
Vitamin D3	The vitamin a gecko needs to absorb and use calcium. It builds up in the body, so more is not safer. Page 8.

REFERENCE

Sources

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Species references

- ReptiFiles: Gargoyle Gecko Care Guide and Gargoyle Gecko Food. Insects twice a week for adults and the pinky mouse limit; adult size of 8 to 10 in, adult weight of 45 to 65 g, maturity, lifespan, habitat and color.
- ReptiFiles: Gargoyle Gecko Humidity and Temperatures. The 86°F (30°C) ceiling and 65°F (18°C) floor, the 50 to 70% average, the heavy evening and optional morning mist, and drinking droplets rather than from a dish.
- ReptiFiles: Metabolic Bone Disease, Floppy Tail Syndrome, and Gargoyle Gecko Sexing. Signs and causes of both conditions, where the calcium sacs sit, tail amputation for severe floppy tail, and the 18 to 25 g sexing point.
- Reptiles Magazine: Gargoyle Gecko Care Sheet, and Breeding Gargoyle Geckos. Weight at maturity, two-egg clutches, male breeding age, room-temperature incubation for 70 to 90 days, hatchling housing, and tail loss in breeding males.
- Lozito and colleagues (2024), *Gigabyte*: the crested gecko genome assembly, and the finding that crested geckos cannot regrow a tail while gargoyles can.
- Reaction to novel objects and fecal stress-hormone levels in two species of nocturnal geckos (PMC10649715): the stress comparison of two nocturnal gecko species, the crested gecko among them, used in the enrichment section.
- Bashaw and colleagues (2016), *Applied Animal Behaviour Science*: leopard geckos respond to five types of environmental enrichment, with temperature and feeding ranked highest.
- The Bio Dude: Gargoyle Gecko Care Sheet and Maintenance. Feeding by age, gut-loading for 24 to 48 hours, the 24×24×24 in ideal, and the hatchling weight.
- Bowling Green State University Herpetarium: New Caledonian Gargoyle Gecko. Maturity at around 40 g and 12 to 18 months, 4 to 5 clutches at 4.5 to 6 week intervals, about 6 laying years, and males fighting.
- Zoo Med Laboratories: the ReptiSun 5.0 and 10.0 UVB T5 HO product pages. Tube lengths and wattages.

Veterinary and public health references

- Merck Veterinary Manual: Management and Husbandry of Reptiles. The 3 to 6 month quarantine, ventilation and disease, fluorescent UVB within 12 in (30 cm), glass blocking UVB, and drinking from droplets.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: Nutritional, Metabolic, and Endocrine Diseases of Reptiles. Bone disease causes, signs, diagnosis, treatment and outlook; gout; obesity and fatty liver.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: Reproductive Diseases of Reptiles. Egg binding that develops over weeks or months, diagnosis, and surgery; prolapsed tissues.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: Environmental Diseases and Traumatic Injuries of Reptiles. Causes of stuck shed.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: Bacterial Diseases of Reptiles. Respiratory infection causes, signs, culture and spread to the blood; mouth rot.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: Parasitic Diseases of Reptiles. Cryptosporidiosis in geckos, and lizard mites.
- Merck Veterinary Manual, pet owner edition: Disorders and Diseases of Reptiles. Dehydration signs and fluids, mouth rot signs, and the causes of prolapse.
- VCA Animal Hospitals (originally Veterinary Centers of America): Reptiles, Dystocia. Single females becoming gravid, the signs, causes, treatment and prevention of egg binding, and spaying.
- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: *Salmonella* outbreak linked to pet geckos, closed January 2026. Case, hospitalization and state counts, and the hygiene rules.

Beastly Facts guides drawn on

The gargoyle gecko tank setup, feeding, health issues, handling, enrichment and cost guides, the gargoyle gecko encyclopedia entry and care guide, and the gargoyle, mourning and African fat-tailed gecko overview; the reptile quarantine, *Salmonella* and hygiene, emergency plan, shedding, stool and urates, heating and thermostat, UVB lighting and gut-loading guides; and the crested gecko feeding and cost guides, for the made-up diet removal window and the heat bulb and thermostat prices. The class-wide state rules on page 19 come from each state's wildlife agency rules.

REFERENCE

Where the sources disagree, version history & about

Where credible sources give different numbers, this package prints one and says why.

TOPIC	WHAT THE SOURCES SAY	WHAT THIS PACKAGE USES
Adult size	7 to 9 in; 8 to 10 in; about 8 in total, 6 to 7 in on average	7 to 9 in (18 to 23 cm), with the 8 to 10 in figure noted
Adult weight	About 35 g at maturity; maturity around 40 g; 45 to 65 g as adults	The whole spread, as a growth table rather than a target
Temperatures	Basking 82 to 85°F, or 84°F; cool end 70 to 75°F, or 72 to 74°F; days 78 to 82°F; nights 65 to 72°F, 68 to 77°F, or the low 70s	Basking 82 to 85°F (28 to 29°C), cool end 70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C), 86°F (30°C) ceiling and 65°F (18°C) floor from the species reference
Humidity	50 to 70%; 60 to 80%; at least 50%, preferably 70%	50 to 70% average, with a daily dry-back toward 50%
Adult powder	Every 2 to 3 days; every other day; three times a week	Every 2 to 3 days, corrected by weight
Adult insects	Once a week; twice a week; 1 to 2 times a week by body condition; three times a week as the main diet	1 to 2 times a week, by body condition. The twice-a-month limit is for pinky mice, not insects
UVB tube life	Every 6 months; every 9 to 12 months; once a year	Every 6 to 12 months on the maker's schedule, budgeted at two a year
Enclosure	A 20-gallon tank; 18×18×24 in; 24×24×24 in ideal	18×18×24 in (46×46×61 cm) minimum, 24×24×24 in (61×61×61 cm) ideal
Lifespan	About 15 years; 15 to 20	15 to 20 years, some past 20
Calcium sacs	Under the throat; at the back of the roof of the mouth	The roof of the mouth; a vet checks them

Version history

This is edition 1.1 (Oct 2026). The store page shows the current edition; re-download free if yours is older. Where this list and a page disagree, the page wins.

- **1.1, Oct 2026.** Aligned to the current layout: cover icon, section order, page pointers, a units note and glossary entry, and one outside organization name taken out of the care text. Safety: UVB is a 12 in 5.0 (5%) T5 HO tube, with the basking spot 6 to 12 in below it. Costs: every item priced and rounded to the nearest \$5; setup \$350 to \$660, yearly \$320 to \$565; the budget now over two pages. Other changes are wording only.
- **1.0, Oct 2026.** First edition, 41 pages.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the listed sources and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for a veterinarian who treats reptiles, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit. Treatments described here are for recognizing what a vet may do, not for use at home, and every medication dose is set by the vet.

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